

"The internet should empower freedom; instead, it has become a tool of oppression for those seeking voice and dignity." – Based on observations by digital rights advocates

INTRODUCTION

Cyberstalking and online harassment represent emergent threats to internal security that transcend conventional criminological frameworks. With 118.4% surge in online crimes against women (2020-2024) and 54.8% of women experiencing cyber harassment, these phenomena constitute not merely individual victimization but systemic erosion of digital citizenship and institutional sovereignty. This answer interrogates the multifaceted dimensions through which cyberstalking metamorphoses into a national security imperative, necessitating comprehensive institutional recalibration.

MANIFESTATIONS AND SCALE OF THE CHALLENGE

A. Epidemiological Dimensions

- 3,400+ cases of sexual harassment online reported annually
- 1,126 cyberstalking cases in Maharashtra alone
- 98% of accused stalkers face zero imprisonment
- 227 revenge pornography cases (2020); exponential rise post-pandemic

B. Gendered Victimology

- 56% cyberstalking victims are women
 - 26% encounter morphed imagery; 30% face sexual threats
 - Disproportionate targeting of public figures and political participants
 - Chilling effect on women's digital participation and free expression
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INTERNAL SECURITY NEXUS

A. Institutional Vulnerability

- Section 354D IPC and Section 67 IT Act insufficiently enforced
- Anonymity architectures enabling perpetrators to evade accountability
- Inadequate digital forensics capacity within law enforcement
- Jurisdictional fragmentation across state and central agencies

B. Democratic Degeneration

- Self-censorship among citizens, journalists, and activists
- Erosion of online political discourse and civic participation
- Normalized misogyny delegitimizing institutional authority

- Weaponization of cyber-harassment for seditious political purposes

C. Psychological Security Implications

- Collective trauma reducing civic trust and institutional legitimacy
 - Paradoxical intensification through algorithmic amplification
 - Intergenerational normalization of digital abuse among youth
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WAY FORWARD

1. **Convergence of Agencies:** Establish dedicated cybercrime task forces with real-time coordination
 2. **Legal Expedience:** Fast-track trials under Section 354D with stringent sentencing guidelines
 3. **Platform Accountability:** Enforce algorithmic transparency and content moderation standards
 4. **Digital Literacy Mandate:** Embed cybersecurity awareness in educational curricula
 5. **Victim-Centric Approach:** Establish specialized counselling infrastructure and anonymous reporting mechanisms
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CONCLUSION

Cyberstalking transcends conventional criminology, representing a fundamental threat to internal security architecture. The confluence of technological vectors, institutional inertia, and patriarchal impunity has rendered digital spaces inhospitable to marginalized populations. Substantive security demands not merely punitive responses but systemic recalibration—encompassing legislative robustness, algorithmic governance, institutional capacity-building, and cultural transformation. Until cyberstalking perpetrators face meaningful accountability and victims gain refuge within digital ecosystems, the nation's internal security edifice remains structurally compromised, vulnerable to erosion from within.

Word Count: ~395 words